

Left (top to bottom) Pacific oysters on sale in the Sydney Fish Market, Australia; fishing boats and Mures Seafood Restaurant, reflected in Victoria Dock, Hobart, Tasmania;

eating fresh oysters at the Swan Oyster Depot, San Francisco **Below (top to bottom)** Preparing oysters at the Galway Oyster Festival, Ireland; oysters on sale in Cancale, France



Doyles on the Beach moderate

11 Marine Parade, Watson's Bay; www.doyles.com.au

With harbor views to downtown Sydney and a beachfront location, Doyles at Watson's Bay is one of Australia's iconic dining experiences. Highlights include creamy oysters Mornay and oysters Kilpatrick.

Sydney Cove Oyster Bar expensive

1 East Circular Quay; www.sydneycoveoysterbar.com

With unbeatable views of the cosmopolitan waterborne buzz of Circular Quay, this quintessential Sydney restaurant specializes in seafood – especially oysters – caught off New South Wales.

NEW ORLEANS, LA

From oysters Bienville and Rockefeller to po' boys, New Orleans has inspired more iconic oyster recipes than any other city.

Felix's Restaurant & Oyster Bar moderate

739 Iberville St., French Quarter; www.felixs.com

Felix's stays true to its 100-plus years of French Quarter history, and remains a favorite for New Orleans natives. After a night out on Bourbon Street, freshly shucked oysters and a Cajun-style Bloody Mary cocktail make for a reviving brunch.

Drago's Seafood Restaurant expensive

3232 North Arnoult Road, Metairie; www.dragosrestaurant.com

Grilled oysters dot the menus of many New Orleans restaurants, but reputedly Drago's served them first in 1993. Try the locally grown Louisiana bivalves with peanuts and red pepper aioli, or with sun-dried tomatoes and pine nuts for a Mediterranean spin.

SAN FRANCISCO, CA

The oldest of this city's oyster bars opened in 1912, and San Francisco's love affair with briny bivalves shows no sign of slowing down. North America's best farmers' markets are here too, and keep the local culinary scene buzzing.

Swan Oyster Depot moderate

1517 Polk St. (between California St. & Sacramento St.); (415) 673 1101

Behind a century-old marble counter in this impossibly narrow restaurant, the wisecracking Sancimino brothers serve up oysters from around North America and the Pacific. Customers usually have to stand in line, but both the jokes and the oysters are worth waiting for.

Hog Island moderate

Ferry Building Marketplace, One Ferry Building #11; www.hogislandoysters.com

Pacific? Atlantic? West Coast? East Coast? There's a different selection of American oysters every day at this sleek, modern oyster bar in San Francisco's iconic Ferry Building. On Saturday mornings the action flows outside to the weekly farmers' market.

GALWAY, IRELAND

Caressed by brisk Atlantic gusts on Ireland's west coast, Galway's combination of salt water and fresh water produces exceptional oysters. This slice of natural good fortune is celebrated each September at the Galway International Oyster Festival (www.galwayoysterfest.com).

Conlon & Sons moderate

Eglinton St., Galway City; +353 91 562 268

Surrounded by Galway's best pubs, a big night in the city often kicks off at Conlon & Sons. From September to April, Galway oysters are served at the granite bar, and salmon, scallops, and mussels prove irresistible to seafood buffs.

Moran's Oyster Cottage moderate

The Weir, Kilcolgan; www.moransoystercottage.com

Moran's treats local Clarinbridge oysters simply and with respect; freshly shucked and served with a silky pint of Guinness and some Irish soda bread. A restaurant that's been run by the same family for seven generations really doesn't have a lot to prove.

CANCALE, FRANCE

The Romans, King Louis XIV, Marie Antoinette, and Napoleon Bonaparte were all fans of oysters from Cancale, in northwest France. Local *huîtres* include the delicate and nutty Plate Belon, and the robust and rare Pied de Cheval.

Quai Gambetta inexpensive

Just yards from Cancale's oyster beds, several enterprising locals on the quay offer a fresh dozen with a wedge of lemon for around €4. Ad hoc and alfresco dining is enhanced by salty Atlantic breezes.

A Contre Courant moderate

3 Place du Calvaire, 'Le Port', Cancale; www.acontrecourant.net

With modern decor and regular exhibitions from local artists, A Contre Courant resembles a breezy slice of the Med on France's Atlantic coast. Oysters are treated simply, and the wider menu includes scallops with *andouille* sausage and grilled shrimp skewers.